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THE DANCE OF CHAMPIONS

In tennis, **timing** can be the difference between merely hitting the ball and truly commanding the court. Paul Fein shares tips on how to get it right.

Paul Fein

Whether an athlete blocks a shot in basketball, lands a counterpunch in boxing, or hits a pitch in baseball, he needs excellent timing. In fact, this fundamental skill is critical in almost every sport. And none more so than in tennis, where every shot requires contacting a moving ball with precision while almost always on the run, except when serving. Precise timing generates power, ensures accuracy, and increases consistency.

World-class tennis players make timing the most difficult shots look easy. In addition to their superb athleticism, elite coaching, and intensive practice, they understand the keys to great timing. Let's review the basics as well as

the fine points of tennis timing. Then you can evaluate your timing and identify areas where you can improve.

Adjust your timing to the existing conditions

Note the weather conditions: The speed and direction of the wind, the temperature, the humidity, and precipitation (if any). Determine how each of these variables affects your timing and adjust your timing accordingly. Given that the narrowness of a singles court is 27 feet (8.23 metres) compared to several other sports — especially the expansive, diamond-shaped baseball field — a shot contacted too early or late can easily land outside the singles sideline in the doubles alley for an error.

Wind poses the most common and vexing timing challenge. Note the speed, direction,